How to Safely Browse the Internet

Purpose:

The purpose of this document is to highlight effective patterns that will help you, the user, be more conscientious about how to browse the web safely and not be duped by bogus websites whose intent is to steal your credentials.

Necessary Items:

- Computer
- Internet Access
- Web Browser (i.e. Chrome, IE, Safari, Firefox)

Instructions:

Step 1: Turn on the computer and open a web browser. (Figure 1)

Turn on the computer and log in. Once you've logged in as a User, in your desktop open the web browser. Double-click the browser Icon and the browser will open at a specified home page.

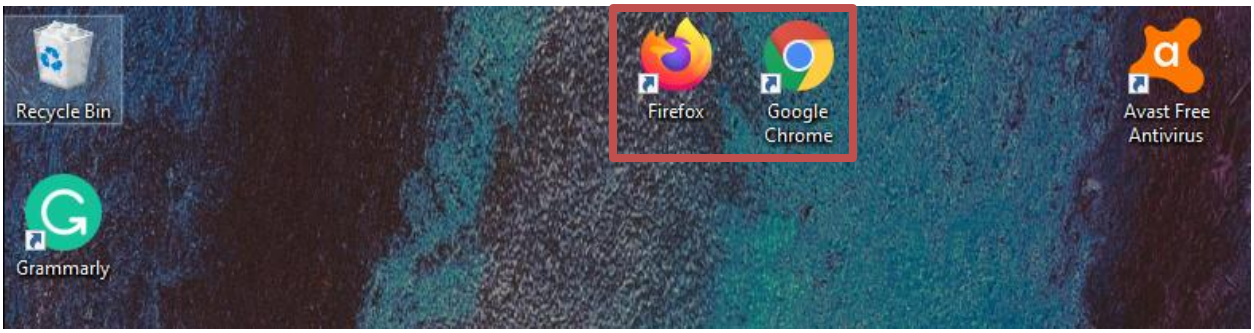

Figure 1: Desktop View with Web Browser Examples (Firefox, Chrome)

Notes: It's good to stick to one browser to understand how it behaves when it loads websites and get used to where things pop up on the browser and its usability. While you don't have to it's highly suggested.

Step 2: Type the website you wish to access and then check protocol (Figure 2)

With the browser open, type in the website that you wish to access in the address bar and press enter. Once the website loads you can see whether it is using a secure transfer protocol or not. You can do this by checking whether the site that loaded is formatted in this matter “https://www.WebsiteIWantToVisit.com”. This will be standard amongst most of the common web browsers.

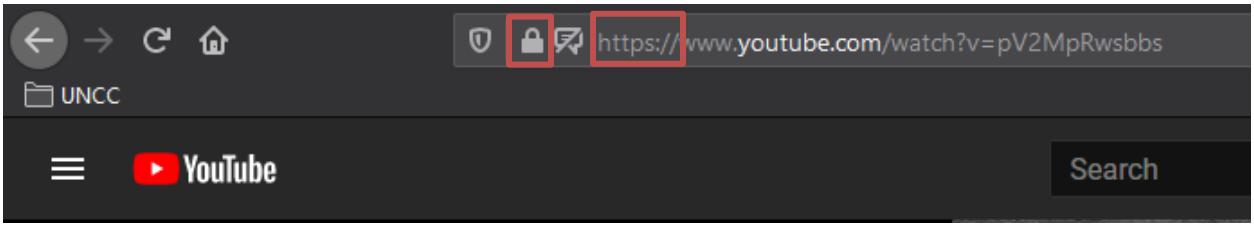

Figure 2: This is a YouTube webpage, detailing the secure transfer protocol

Caution: If the site doesn’t have the “s” at the end of the protocol, meaning it displays “http” it does not mean that you can’t use it. Just be aware that the transfer of data is not secure and could be discovered using tools as an outsider.

Step 3: Check the certificate of the site (Figure 3)

To verify the certificate of security in a site, this is known as an SSL certificate, you want to click the padlock icon and check who certified the certificate. So long as a certificate is issued then most likely the certified site is safe to navigate.

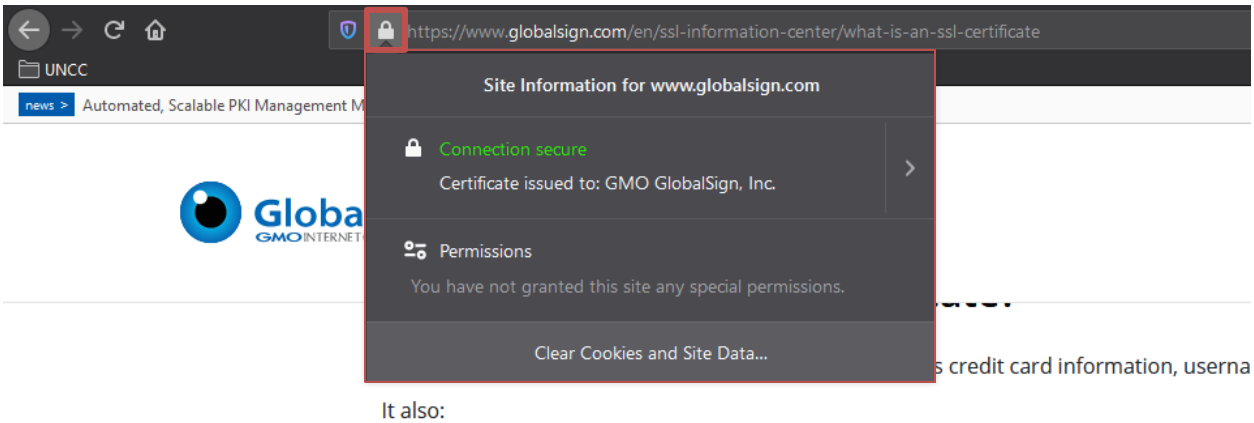

Figure 3: Information Displayed after clicking on Padlock

Step 4: Check Spelling in Address Bar continuously to ensure right site is accessed. (Figure 4)

Throughout your navigation of the website, make sure that the domain name remains the same. If you're about to input sensitive information (such as an email address, password, register an account) always pause to check that the previous steps are valid.

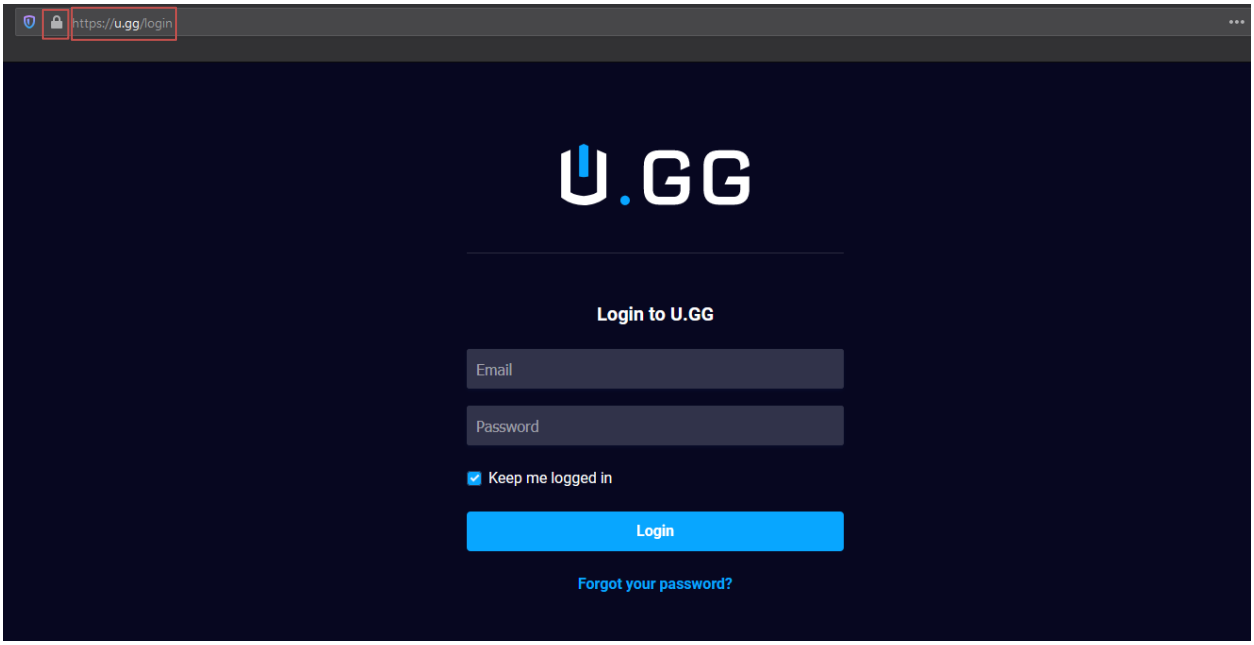

Figure 4: Login page for a popular gaming tool, here you can see all the things you have to check before you proceed to log in or do anything with sensitive information capture. There's a padlock and you have https so we know the secure protocol is active and the information will be encrypted. And it's the intended site because it's exactly the company/tool name and the correct extension (gg – most commonly used by gaming sites)

Danger: If the site has extra lettering or numbering that you know is not common to the site close the browser immediately. The objective is to catch this before you input any information. In this example a fake site would be u6.gg which is not legitimate and most likely would not have the padlock when accessed.

Step 5: Check hyperlinks before clicking them to ensure they don't take you to an unwanted site. (Figure 5)

You can hover over most links and be able to see where they direct you to before clicking them.

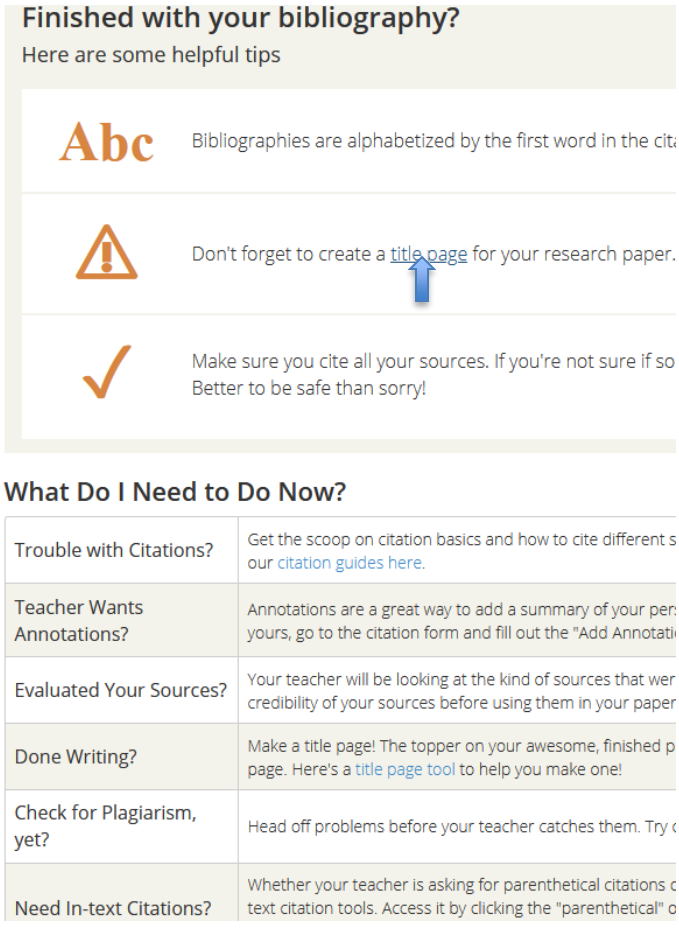

Figure 5: Hovering over the title page link will display where the page will take you after the link in clicked

Caution: Be sure to only hover over the link with your mouse pointer and not actually click the link. Most Web Browsers will display the link it redirects to at the bottom left. You should see it pop up while hovering only.

Step 6: Never save log in information on a web browser. (Figure 6)

Yes, saving log in information or other details is useful to you as a user, but highly vulnerable to web attacks. This also extends to any shopping cart forms, any form where you input sensitive information.

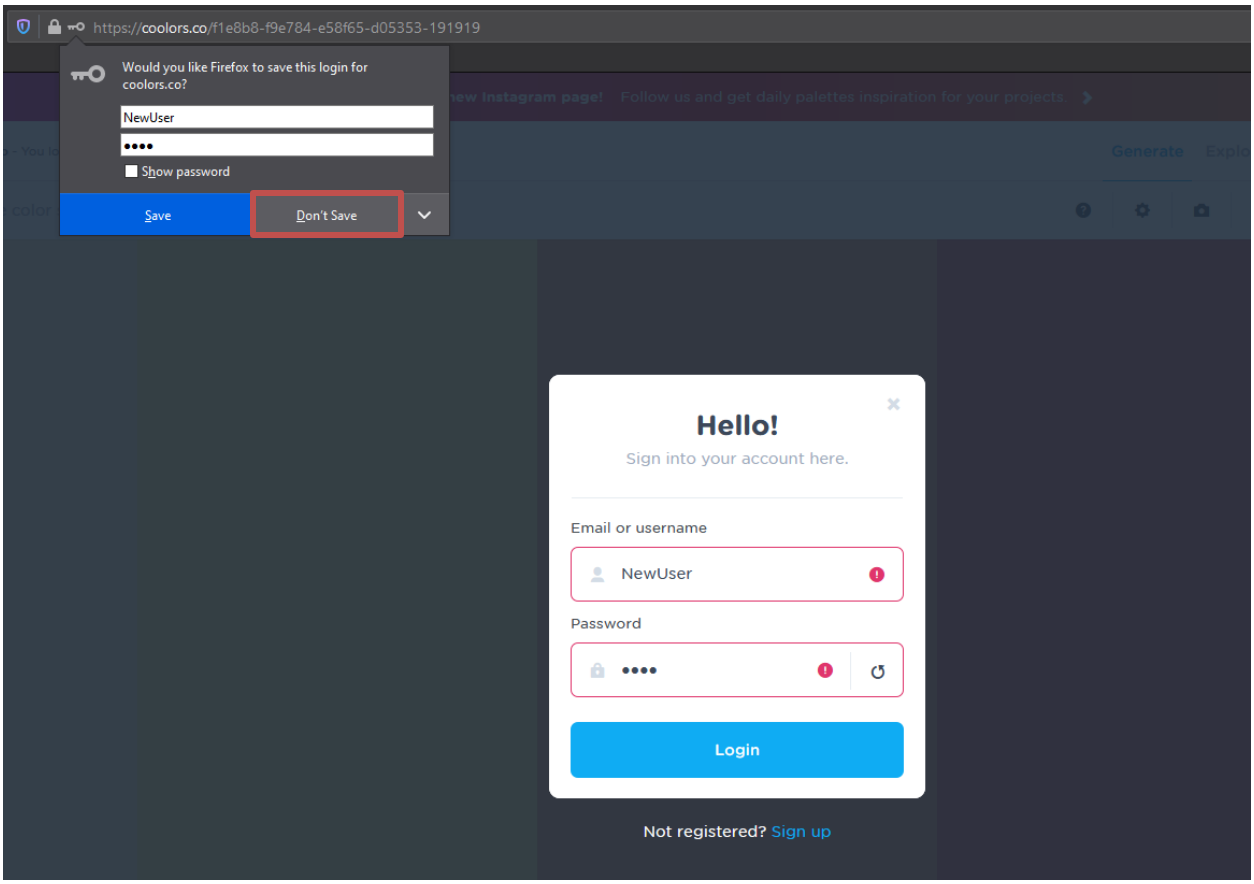

Figure 6: Attempt to log in and request to save log in information displays.

Sources

U.GG, Outplayed, Inc., 17 Feb. 2020, u.gg/.

Beal, Vangie. "Padlock Icon." *What Is a Browser Padlock Icon? Webopedia Definition*, QuinStreet Inc., www.webopedia.com/TERM/P/padlock-icon.html.

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